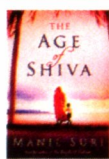


ALL ABOUT MOTHER

The tragedy of the feminine comes alive in Manil Suri's sprawling human saga set in a historical backdrop



THE AGE OF SHIVA
by MANIL SURI
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■ By S. Prasannarajan

Six years ago, we opened a mathematician's first novel to see a dying god in the lowest landing of an apartment building in Kemp's Corner, Mumbai: a drunken reincarnate who "lay sprawled on the stone, his figure aligned with the curve of the stairs". *The Death of Vishnu*, with its pre-publication buzz about a six-figure advance for the American rights alone to a debut by a young professor who specialises in the "numerical analysis of partial differential equations" at the University of Maryland, came to us with big-bang expectations, and it didn't let us down. Sprawled across the pages of neo-realistic precision was a narrative that brought out the everyday drama of reason and religion, of doubt and faith, with the god outcast as the mute witness. Manil Suri's suburban Vishnu *pu-rana* with a dash of Bollywood was, we were told, the first of a trilogy, to be followed by *Shiva* and *Brahma*. So here it is. *The Age of Shiva*, larger in size and ambition, may not be a sequel to *Vishnu*, but Suri's second novel is powered by the same grace and passion that made his first an instant hit.

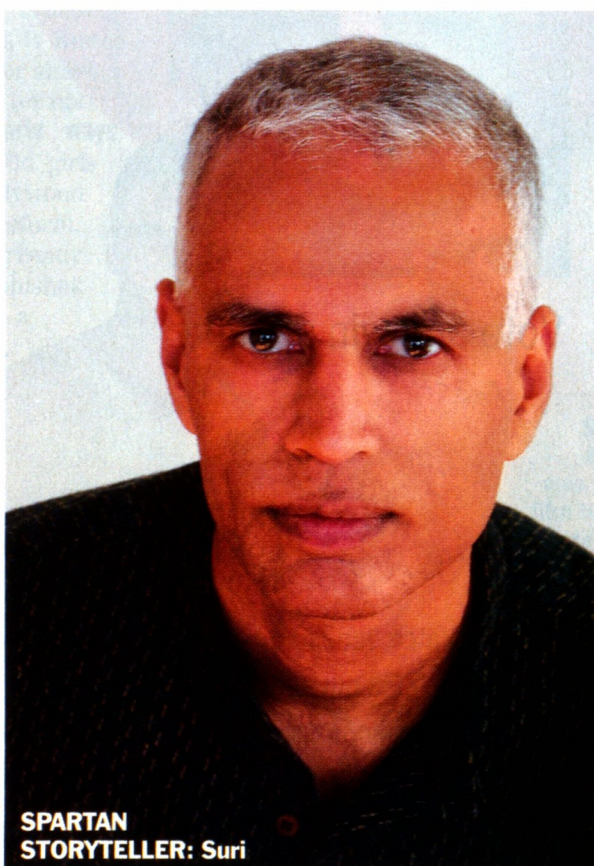
At the centre of this novel is not a god—in spite of the title—but a mother, a rare one in Indian fiction in English. She is the narrator, and the axis of this novel in which history is a per-

manent echo. The mother is telling a story—the story of her life, the story of her times, the story of a country that moves with stoic elasticity from the agony of Partition and the romance of liberation to the temptations of power and the hatred of faith—to her son. She is reliving a world she has lost, a world she struggles to regain but she can't. Suri, like a docu-dramatist who maintains a safe distance from the scene of action, builds her character to awesome perfection, as if everyone else in this overpopulated book is sustained by her energy. As lover, daughter, sister, wife, widow, eroticist, friend and mother, Meera overwhelms the narrative, and her back story and future are inseparable from the spasmodic rhythm of history.

The novel opens with an invocation: "Every time I touch you, every time I kiss you, every time I offer you my body. Ashvin. Do you know how tightly you shut your eyes as with your lips you

search my skin? Do you know how you thrust your feet towards me, how you reach out your arms...?" This tender eroticism between mother and son will be played out in varying degrees of innocence and guilt across the book, which at one level is a love story animated by the limits and transgressions of the relationship between mother and son. The novelist draws from the Shiva-Parvati myth to add extra-poignancy to the story of Meera and Ashvin, who carries within him, as explained elsewhere in the novel, both Vishnu and Shiva. Rearrange the first five letters in Ashvin and we get Shiva; replace the letter A with U and it becomes an anagram of Vishnu—the novelist tells us. Still, this novel is more than love and death in the age of Shiva.

In an accidental confluence of the personal and the political, Meera's story is kick-started by an inspiring line from Nehru's Independence Day speech: "Are we brave enough and



SPARTAN STORYTELLER: Suri

EXCERPT

Every time I touch you, every time I kiss you, every time I offer you my body. Ashvin. Do you know how tightly you shut your eyes as with your lips you search my skin? Do you know how you thrust your feet towards me, how you reach out your arms, how the sides of your chest strain against my palms? Are you aware of your fingers brushing against my breast, their tips trying to curl around something to hold on to, but slipping instead against my smooth flesh?

Ashvin. Do you notice the wetness emerge from my nipples and spill down the slopes of my chest? Is that your tongue that I feel, are you able to steal a taste or two?

Ashvin. Your eyes still closed, drops of moisture dappling your nose. Do you know how innocent you look, how helpless, as I guide the nipple towards towards your mouth? For an instant, I feel like teasing you. Drawing my nipple across your lips, but only for a touch, and swinging it away.